in the administration who still are nostalgic for General Musharraf. It is always easier to deal with a general and a single person than a complicated coalition government.

And what you have between Mr. Zardari and the PPP and Mr. Sharif and his party is an uneasy grand coalition, similar to Israel. That is not a very easy way to govern. But it is what the people wanted. And the most important thing to note is that the militant Islamic parties got only about 4 or 5 percent of the vote, a very dramatic repudiation of the journalistic cliche´ that Pakistan is the world's most dangerous nation. It is not the world's most dangerous nation, however, its tribal areas do pose a problem for us and must be paid attention to.

So I would say that the domestic situation in Islamabad—and I happened to be there just as the National Assembly was taking office and I spent a lot of time with the new parliamentarians, and I saw the spirit and energy, that is an encouraging situation. But it needs strong American support. And I might say, it needs American understanding because democracy is not always a clean process.

But the diminution of President Musharraf's power is in the interests of the country. And to his credit he seems to have accepted it. As we speak now, very complicated negotiations are going on between Prime Minister Galani, President Musharraf and the two party leaders, neither of whom are in the Parliament of course, over the future of the presidency. America's voice must be clear here: The best thing for Pakistan is democracy internally.

However, there is no democracy in the Tribal Areas. As everyone knows, the Tribal Areas, often called the Federally Administered Tribal Areas, so if I might I will call them FATA without confusing them with a certain other Fatah to the west, the FATA areas are not democratic. Political parties are not allowed. They are administered under a law written by the British under the Indian Raj in 1901, and they are run in a very peculiar way. And this situation has led rise to a tremendous opportunity for the militants when they were driven out of Afghanistan. This delicate balance of independent tribes going back centuries worked until the United States successfully drove the Taliban out of much of Afghanistan in 2001, 2002, and the Taliban and al-Qaeda moved across the border into these areas, stirring up immense amounts of trouble which is continuing.

I went to Peshawar. I went up to the Khyber Pass; I met with the Frontier Corps leadership. And I will tell you frankly, Mr. Chairman, I do not have a clue what is going on in the FATA. And if anyone ever comes before this committee and says so you better ask twice, because it is one of the most elusive areas in the world.

But to go back to what you and your colleagues have just said, it is absolutely true, as the GAO has said, that there is not strategy for the United States. Worst than that, the Pakistani Government which is focused on its internal domestic line-up in this new era of democracy in Pakistan after a decade of military rule, is also not clear what it is doing. There are very credible rumors and concerns that one of the things that the government might do is to cut deals with some of the militants that would allow them to have a free hand in Afghanistan if they stayed out of the populated areas to the east in Pakistan. Two years ago when Musharraf tried a similar deal it was a disaster. And by the way, when I saw him privately he admitted that it did not work out very well.

Everyone says, ''Oh, this one would be different.'' But the truth is, Mr. Chairman, you, the members of the committee, we at this witness table, none of us know what is being negotiated there. The only thing we know is that it is of the most immense importance to American security interests and will directly affect the lives of NATO forces, especially

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